

USUCGER 2026 Annual Meeting Minutes

Tuesday, March 10, 2026

11:00 a.m. – 12:00 p.m. Mountain Time

Room 355A, Salt Palace Convention Center, Salt Lake City, UT, and via Zoom

Diane Moug (USUCGER President) presided over the 2026 USUCGER Annual Meeting. The meeting minutes were prepared by Jim Kaklamanos (USUCGER Secretary).

Attendees (in-person and online), $n = 49$:

USUCGER Board Members (including ex-officio members):

- Diane Moug, Portland State University, USUCGER President
- Jim Kaklamanos, Merrimack College, USUCGER Secretary
- Joseph Coe, San Jose State University, USUCGER Treasurer
- Estéfan Garcia, University of Michigan, USUCGER Membership Coordinator
- Chukwuebuka Nweke, University of Southern California, USUCGER Webmaster
- Jack Montgomery, Auburn University, USUCGER Past President
- Marika Santagata, Purdue University
- Ryan Shamet, University of North Florida
- Lisa Star, California State University, Long Beach
- Kaleigh Yost, Penn State University

Attendees:

- Yasaman Abdolvand, Michigan Tech
- Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos, University of California, Berkeley
- Jean-Louis Briaud, Texas A&M University
- Jonathan Bray, University of California, Berkeley
- Susan Burns, Georgia Tech
- Sandeep Chitta, Michigan Tech
- Timothy Copeland, University of Central Florida
- Sheng Dai, Georgia Tech
- Pingki Datta, Oregon State University (student travel grant recipient)
- Theresa Engler, Deep Foundations Institute
- Jongwan Eun, University of Maryland
- Matt Evans, Oregon State University
- Pegah Ghasemi, University of North Florida
- Russell Green, Virginia Tech
- Kyle Kershaw, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology
- Alex Lefever, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology (student travel grant recipient)
- Laura Luna, Utah State University
- Kami Mohammadi, University of Utah
- Brina Montoya, North Carolina State University
- Silas Nichols, Federal Highway Administration
- Tobi Ogunro, University of North Carolina at Charlotte
- Fernando Patino, Georgia Tech
- Ryan Rasanen, University of North Carolina at Charlotte
- Helen Robinson, GEI Consultants

- Shahrzad Roshankhah, University of Utah
- Mo Sadeghi, Michigan Tech
- Emmanuel Salifu, Arizona State University
- Anna Shidlovshaya, Terracon
- Julian Tao, Arizona State University
- Burak Tanyu, George Mason University
- Anthony Tessari, Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute
- Nitin Tiwari, Southern Illinois University Carbondale
- Joe Wartman, University of Washington
- Kam Ng, University of Wyoming
- Claudia Zapata, Arizona State University
- Yumeng Zhao, University of Nebraska, Lincoln
- Cheng Zhu, Rowan University
- Yichuan Zhu, Temple University
- Katerina Ziotopoulou, University of California, Davis

Minutes:

1. Introductions and welcome of new board members (Diane Moug, President)
 - a. The meeting was called to order at 11:06 a.m. Mountain Time.
 - b. Diane introduced the two new Board members to the membership:
 - i. Alejandro Martinez (University of California, Davis)
 - ii. Chukwuebuka Nweke (University of Southern California)
 - c. Diane also recognized three outgoing Board members and thanked them for their service to the organization:
 - i. Alesandra Morales
 - ii. Jack Montgomery (ex-officio, Past-President)
 - iii. Joseph Coe (ex-officio, Treasurer)
2. Treasurer's report (Diane Moug, President; on behalf of Joseph Coe, Treasurer)
 - a. USUCGER has two accounts: a bank account and a PayPal account. Membership dues are deposited into the PayPal account, and funds are occasionally transferred to the bank account.
 - b. As of March 9, 2026, there are a total of \$22,336.43 in total assets, with \$21,836 in the bank account and \$500 in the PayPal account (corrected from the original meeting slides).
 - c. All revenues come from membership dues, at \$75 per member for three years (i.e., equivalent to \$25 per person per year). In the current membership drive (2025-27), 312 members have paid as of 3/9/2026, resulting in approximately \$22,430 in dues.
 - d. A recent major expenditure was the Early Career Workshop. Other expenses include the special project, student travel awards, and webhosting.
3. Webmaster's report (Diane Moug, President)
 - a. Diane recognized outgoing webmaster Kristin Sample-Lord and thanked her for her years of service. She announced that Chukwuebuka Nweke will be the incoming webmaster and thanked him for volunteering to serve in this role.
 - b. The most trafficked page is still the Academic Job Postings page.

- c. A new Membership Directory page is now live: <https://usucger.org/membership-directory/>; this listing includes all members who have paid 2025-2027 dues. The page is updated monthly.
- 4. USUCGER Membership and Dues (Estéfan Garcia, Membership Coordinator)
 - a. Estéfan provided an update on the current 2025 – 2027 dues cycle. Just over 300 members have fully paid, and he will be sending reminder emails in the coming weeks to institutions with members who have not fully paid their membership dues.
 - b. Estéfan noted that a university is considered fully paid if dues are paid on behalf of all of their *active geotechnical faculty*, i.e. research faculty, teaching faculty, tenured/tenure-track faculty, active emeritus faculty, etc. Inactive faculty are those who have fully retired, moved to administrative/leadership positions, or any other change in position that no longer involves active geotechnical education/research.
 - c. Dues remain at \$75 per member for the three-year cycle (i.e., \$25 per person per year) and are not prorated. This fee is per person and not per university or organization. You can find all the details and pay your dues here: <https://usucger.org/usucger-membership-overview/>.
 - d. If you do not remember if you paid your dues, check for your name in the USUCGER membership directory: <https://usucger.org/membership-directory/>.
 - e. Estéfan is leading a new initiative that proposes adding specialty categories within the membership directory (i.e., representing different areas of expertise within geotechnical engineering), with the goal of connecting members by areas of expertise.
- 5. USUCGER Special Project update (provided by Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos, University of California, Berkeley)
 - a. Adda provided an update on the ongoing USUCGER Special Project, “Next-Generation Geotechnical Engineering Education: Coding, AI, and Automation,” being conducted by PIs Mohamad Hallal and Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos at University of California, Berkeley.
 - b. The project deliverable will be six modular assignments covering core geotechnical topics in an undergraduate soil mechanics course: (1) soil classification, (2) Mohr’s Circle, (3) stress distribution, (4) flow nets, (5) consolidation, and (6) compaction. Each assignment will include three components: (1) hand calculations, (2) coding implementation, and (3) AI integration.
 - c. Five of the six assignments are complete, with compaction being the only assignment remaining. The initial feedback is that AI was more effective for soil classification but less so for Mohr’s Circle.
 - d. Adda provided a QR code for those interested in reviewing draft assignments or pilot testing them.
- 6. USUCGER Early Career Workshop (Susan Burns, Georgia Tech)
 - a. Georgia Tech successfully hosted the Third USUCGER Early Career Workshop from 15-17 October 2025, with 44 Assistant Professors from 42 universities attending.
 - b. The workshop was funded by the National Science Foundation, the USUCGER, the Deep Foundations Institute, and the Georgia Institute of Technology.

- c. Workshop sessions focused on: advancing an academic career in a changing environment, and research strategies: developing vision and a high-impact research program.
- 7. USUCGER Awards Ceremony (Diane Moug, President)
 - a. On behalf of the USUCGER Board of Directors, Diane presented the USUCGER 2026 Early Career Educator Award to Cheng Zhu (Rowan University) and the USUCGER 2026 Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Award to Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos (University of California, Berkeley). Diane presented each recipient an award certificate, delivered a statement about each recipient, and then offered the awardee the opportunity to deliver remarks.
 - b. USUCGER 2026 Early Career Educator Award: Cheng Zhu, Associate Professor, Rowan University
 - i. In bestowing the award, Diane noted how impressed the Board was Cheng's mentorship of undergraduate students.
 - ii. Cheng expressed his gratitude for receiving this award, discussing his work with students both in teaching and research, and the engineering clinic approach at Rowan that allows for close collaborations between students and professors.
 - c. USUCGER 2026 Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Award: Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos, Associate Professor, University of California, Berkeley
 - i. In bestowing the award, Diane noted how important diversity, equity, and inclusion has been across many of Adda's professional initiatives.
 - ii. Adda discussed how she began pursuing efforts related to diversity, equity, and inclusion; she was a faculty member in a department where there were few women, and she wanted to increase the number of women in geotechnical engineering like herself. Adda expressed gratitude for this award from USUCGER and noted that it is truly rewarding to see these efforts recognized.
 - d. Recognition of USUCGER Student Travel Grant recipients
 - i. USUCGER supported two students from member universities to attend ASCE GeoCongress 2026, and both of them were present at the USUCGER Annual Meeting to be recognized:
 - 1. Pingki Datta, PhD Student, Oregon State University
 - 2. Alex Lefever, Senior Undergraduate Student, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology
 - ii. Diane also recognized two other student travel grant recipients outside of the Spring 2026 award cycle:
 - 1. Fall 2025 cycle: Sajan KC, PhD Candidate, University of Southern California, 2025 GeoExtreme
 - 2. Summer 2025 cycle: Avishek Ghosh, PhD Candidate, South Dakota State University, 2025 International Conference of Bio-mediated and Bio-inspired Geotechnics
 - iii. The USUCGER Board will be accepting applications for Summer 2026 conferences (i.e., travel from May 1 to August 31 of this year), and the deadline has been extended to March 20, 2026. Board member Kaleigh Yost is leading the process. The awards will be up to \$1,000 per

- student and may be used to fund the attendee's airfare, hotel, per diem, and/or the conference student registration fee.
- e. Jean-Louis Briaud, Texas A&M University, noted that there are other avenues besides USUCGER (such as Geo-Institute and ASCE websites) for students to pursue funding for conference travel and other initiatives. He would like to see students benefit from funding opportunities in these organizations.
8. USUCGER Future Objectives (discussion led by Diane Moug, President)
- a. The Board is interested in increasing revenue available to USUCGER to open the door for more workshops; student travel grants, special projects, website development, etc. Currently, all our funding comes from membership dues.
 - b. Potential immediate strategy for increasing revenue: Extend access to job postings on the USUCGER site to industry and agencies for a fee
 - i. The idea proposed by Board member Marika Santagata is to charge companies to post jobs on the USUCGER website (academic/university jobs will remain free and separate). Other organizations (such as ASCE, AGU, and AEG) charge hundreds of dollars to post jobs. Discussion and comments from members was solicited.
 - ii. Kyle Kershaw, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology: Suggested some sort of vetting to make sure the jobs are related to geotechnical engineering.
 - iii. Jean-Louis Briaud, Texas A&M University: We want to make sure students will access the job postings. Suggested trying to make the website more student-focused.
 - iv. Jack Montgomery (Auburn University) and Buka Nweke (University of Southern California), on behalf of the Board, mentioned that by far the academic jobs page has the most visits of any page of the website (12,000 visits last year). The Board is also interested in making the website more student-focused.
 - v. Claudia Zapata, Arizona State University: Inquired about increasing dues and perhaps fundraising activities as additional sources of income.
 - vi. Helen Robinson, GEI Consultants (Past President, ASCE G-I Board of Governors): Noted that some companies have restrictions; for example, GEI cannot take resumes directly -- candidates need to apply for positions.
 - vii. Burak Tanyu, George Mason University: USUCGER has both an educational and research component. To that end, many companies would want to contribute to this organization because it will help advance the geotechnical engineering profession. Perhaps private companies could donate and fund research projects (beyond the research that federal agencies such as the National Science Foundation will support).
 - c. Potential longer-term strategy for increasing revenue: Raise USUCGER member dues
 - i. Diane noted that the Board has had discussions about raising USUCGER membership dues in the next cycle (2028-30). Any changes will need to be approved by a membership vote, likely in conjunction with next year's Annual Meeting.

- ii. USUCGER membership dues have been at \$25 per member per year since 2004, and inflation over the past two decades has meant that costs have increased significantly. An increase in revenue from dues would mean that USUCGER could do much more as an organization.
 - iii. Even with a price increase, USUCGER dues would be significantly less than most other professional organizations, all of which have substantially increased dues in the last two decades.
 - iv. Jean-Louis Briaud suggested increasing dues to \$50 per member per year, which is roughly what \$25 per member per year in 2004 would be equivalent to in 2026 with an average inflation rate of 3%.
- d. Promoting more continuous engagement of USUCGER community
 - i. Currently, interaction between members is largely limited to the Annual Meeting and Happy Hour at the ASCE Geo-Congress. Diane discussed some possible strategies, including an additional semi-annual membership “virtual” meeting (late fall), and regular (~every 3 months) virtual conversations around topics of broad interest to the community in form of presentations and/or panels (such as implementing AI in geotechnical engineering education).
 - ii. Jack Montgomery, Auburn University: When USUCGER started in the 1980s, there was an in-person annual meeting composed of geotechnical engineering faculty at a member university, because Geo-Congress did not exist yet.
 - iii. Jean-Louis Briaud, Texas A&M University: Does not recommend removing the current gatherings at Geo-Congress because they are very effective, but suggests supplementing these gatherings with additional ones.
 - iv. Theresa Engler, Deep Foundations Institute: DFI would certainly welcome a meeting of USUCGER at the DFI Annual Conference.
 - v. Members seemed interested in increasing the engagement in some capacity throughout the year.
- 9. Updates from other organizations
 - a. Susan Burns, ASCE Geo-Institute Board of Governors: the Board is seeking to establish a perpetual endowment for student travel grants. The Board is also working on reimaging the international activities of the organization.
 - b. Theresa Engler, Deep Foundations Institute: Membership for faculty is \$75 per year, and membership for students is free. DFI is working to promote industry awareness and advancement, through outreach to engage high school and college students in the foundation industry (for example, with a field demo that was held in California). There is a project fund every year, as well as a traveling lecturer program, along with many publications. Several conferences are coming up later this year that represent additional opportunity for engagement.
 - c. Helen Robinson, Deep Foundations Institute and ASCE Geo-Institute: Helen noted the scholarship opportunities for students through the DFI Educational Trust. They are working to increase industry-academic connections in ways beyond scholarships, such as ambassadors/practitioners connected to institutions, and finding ways to nudge more undergraduates into geotechnical engineering.

For the ASCE 2027 conference, the abstract deadline has been extended, and no papers are required.

- i. Jean-Louis Briaud, Texas A&M University: For promoting geotechnical engineering to undergraduate students, two major things that can have an impact are case histories and field trips.
 - ii. Joe Wartman, University of Washington: Joe is chairing the International Activities Council of the ASCE Geo-Institute. They are working on a new strategic plan that will internationalize the Geo-Institute in a significant way. Joe Wartman will be advertising opportunities for engagement through G-I and USUCGER.
 - d. Diane provided an update from Peggy Hagerty Duffy of ADSC, The International Association of Foundation Drilling:
 - i. The ADSC scholarship application period is live right now: <https://www.adsc-iafd.com/about/industry-advancement-fund/scholarships/>.
 - ii. Also, ADSC will be hosting a Concrete Slam in the Dallas area on April 21st, a one-day workshop on concrete for deep foundations, that would be of interest to many in USUCGER: <https://www.adsc-iafd.com/event/adsc-concrete-slam/>. There is also a student price available.
10. Discussion and questions from members
- a. All discussion occurred in the context of the “USUCGER Future Objectives” portion of the meeting.
 - b. The meeting was adjourned at 11:58 a.m. Mountain Time, and Diane thanked everyone for attending.

Appendix

PowerPoint Slides from USUCGER Annual Meeting



Agenda

2026 USUCGER Annual Meeting

March 10, 11 am - 12 pm (MT)

Agenda

Room 355A, Zoom: <https://pdx.zoom.us/my/dmoug>

1. Introductions and welcome new board members: Alejandro Martinez (University of California, Davis) and Chukwuebuka Nweke (University of Southern California)
2. Treasurer's report (Joseph Coe)
3. Webmaster's report (Kristin Sample-Lord [outgoing] Chukwuebuka Nweke [incoming])
 - a. Website updates
4. USUCGER Membership and Dues (Estéfan Garcia)
 - a. 2025 - 2027 dues cycle update
 - b. Proposed specialty categories for membership directory
5. USUCGER special projects (Mohamad Hallal & Adda Athanasopoulos Zekkos)
 - a. Update on ongoing special project
6. Early Career Research Workshop - Report from Susan Burns (Georgia Tech)
7. USUCGER Awards Ceremony
 - a. Early Career Educator: Cheng Zhu (Rowan University)
 - b. Diversity Equity and Inclusion: Adda Athanasopoulos Zekkos (University of California, Berkeley)
 - c. Recognition of student travel grant winners
8. USUCGER Future Plans
9. Updates from other organizations
10. Discussion and questions from members

Welcome New Board Members



Junior Board Member
Chukwuebuka Nweke
Assistant Professor
University of Southern California



Senior Board Member
Alejandro Martinez
Professor
University of California, Davis

Outgoing Board Members

- Alesandra Morales
- Jack Montgomery (ex-officio Past-President)
- Joseph Coe (ex-officio Treasurer)

Treasurer's Report

Current Financial Status

- Bank Balance: \$21,836.⁴³ (as of 03/09/2026)
- PayPal Balance: \$500.⁰⁰ (as of 03/09/2026)
- Total Assets: \$22,336.⁴³ (as of 03/09/2026)
(-\$23,557.⁹⁰ relative to 07/31/2025)

Updates

- Membership Drive (2025-2027).
 - 312 members paid as of 03/09/2026 (+199 since previous yearly meeting on 04/23/2025)
 - ≈\$22,430 in dues collected during current drive
- Recent Major Expenditures
 - Special Projects (Next-Generation Education in Geotechnical Engineering; PIs: Mohamad Hallal + Adda Zekkos, UC Berkeley)
 - Webhosting
 - Student Travel
 - Early Career Workshop

Webmaster's Report

Webmaster Transition

THANK YOU to outgoing webmaster Kristin Sample Lord

Incoming webmaster will be Buka Nweke

Website Updates

- Most trafficked page is still the Academic Job Postings
- Member directory page visible to see who has paid 2025-2027 dues.
Updated ~ monthly.

USUCGER Membership Directory

(based on 2025-2027 cycle dues collected; alphabetical by University / Organization; last updated 5 February 2026)

First Name	Last Name	University / Organization
Mohammad Wasif	Naqvi	AGR, LLC / Turner-Fairbank Highway Research Center
Edward	Kavazanjian	Arizona State University
Hamed	Kodadaditirkolaei	Arizona State University
Christopher	Lawrence	Arizona State University

Membership Report

Membership Coordinator Updates

2025-2027 Dues Cycle Reports	
Paid Members	304
Paid US University Members	290
Paid Affiliate Members	14
Unpaid Members from US Universities	117
Fully Paid U.S. Universities	94
Unpaid or Partially Paid U.S. Universities	89

- Potential new members are identified with input from the USUCGER community.
- A university is fully paid in its dues if dues are paid on behalf of *all* of their *active* geotechnical faculty.
 - Faculty includes research faculty, teaching faculty, tenured/tenure-track faculty, active emeritus faculty, etc.
 - Inactive faculty are those who have fully retired, moved to administrative/leadership positions, or any other change in position that no longer involves active geotechnical education/research.
 - For any gray areas, feel free to ask the UBoard.
- If you don't remember if you paid your dues, check for your name on the USUCGER website.

New Initiative: Connecting Members by Areas of Expertise

Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning	Geomorphology	Offshore Geotechnics
Dam Engineering	Geophysics	Physical Modeling
Data Management	Geosynthetics	Ports
Deep Excavations	Geotechnical Earthquake Engineering and Soil Dynamics	Reconnaissance of Natural Disasters
Earth Retaining Structures	Green Infrastructure	Remote Sensing
Energy Geotechnics	Ground Improvement	Risk and Reliability
Engineering Geology	Groundwater and Seepage	Rock Mechanics
Engineering Education	Instrumentation and Monitoring	Site Characterization and In-situ Testing
Engineering Seismology	Laboratory Testing	Soil Mechanics
Erosion and Scour	Landslides and Slope Stability	Transportation Geotechnics
Foundation Engineering	Levees	Tunneling and Underground Structures
Geoenvironmental Engineering	Mining	Unsaturated Soils
Geomatics	Numerical and Constitutive Modeling	

Special projects update

USUCGER Special Project Next-Generation Geotechnical Engineering Education: Coding, AI, and Automation

Mohamad M. Hallal & Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos



Integrating AI in Geotechnical Engineering Education

- Artificial intelligence (AI) and large language models (LLMs) are reshaping engineering practice
- **Project Goal:** Modernize undergraduate geotechnical engineering education
- **Approach:** Integrate hand calculations, coding, and AI literacy into introductory soil mechanics courses
- **Project Deliverable:** Six modular assignments covering core geotechnical topics
- **Expected Outcome:** Improve conceptual understanding, build computational and AI literacy, and increase student interest in geotechnical engineering

Instructional Framework

- Each assignment includes three components:
 1. **Hand Calculations**
 - Develop conceptual understanding and engineering intuition
 2. **Coding Implementation**
 - Translate engineering procedures into automated workflows
 3. **AI Integration:**
 - Use AI tools to support problem solving and evaluate limitations
- **Key idea:** Students learn (1) fundamentals, (2) computational skills, and (3) responsible AI use → understand both the capabilities and limitations of AI tools in geotechnical engineering

Progress Update

- **Completed (5 of 6 assignments)**
 1. Soil Classification
 2. Mohr's Circle
 3. Stress Distribution
 4. Flow Nets
 5. Consolidation
- **Remaining:**
 6. Compaction

Example Assignment: Soil Classification



NAI No artificial intelligence - all work submitted should be completely your own - no outside assistance.

PAI Partial artificial intelligence - use AI to supplement your work but you must critically analyze the direction it is going and choose final answers to submit.

FAI Full artificial intelligence - directly submit answers generated by AI.

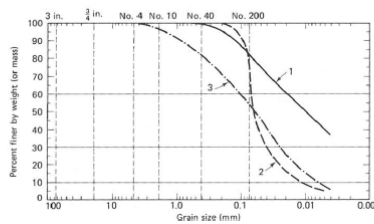
"AI assignment logos" is adapted from "Logos for transparent use of artificial intelligence" © by Martine

Logos to explicitly outline the permitted extent of AI use for each question: (1) none, (2) partial, and (3) full



Question 1: Manual Soil Classification

Grain size distribution curves are given for 3 soils in the figure below. The Liquid Limit and Plastic Limit for the fine-grained portion of these soils are given in the table below. Classify the soils according to ASTM/USCS (i.e., give both the Group Symbol and Group Name). Show your full work and do not use the Python code from Question 2 or any AI tools similar to Question 3.



Soil #	LL	PI
1	46	30
2	30	27
3	75	32

Component 1:
Manual soil classification (No AI)

Example Assignment: Soil Classification



Question 2: Automating Soil Classification with Python

Soil classification involves manual calculations and complex decision trees with numerous branches, sub-branches, and even more branches of classification based on ASTM/USCS standards. This process can be tedious, time-consuming, and prone to human error. Complete [this programming assignment](#), in which you will use Python to automate soil classification, transforming this intricate process into a structured, repeatable, and efficient algorithm.

- Direct link to the coding assignment through Google Colab, which is a cloud-based Jupyter Notebook (no installation needed)
- An autograder is integrated into the coding assignment (students can run a check cell that informs them whether their answer is correct or not)

Example Assignment: Soil Classification

Question 3: Using AI Tools to Support Soil Classification

In this task, you will use an AI-powered assistant (e.g., ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, or another tool of your choice) to help with soil classification.

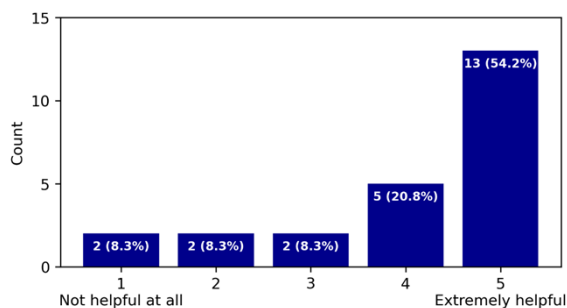
Component 3: AI Integration

- Identify the AI tool you are using (e.g., ChatGPT, Copilot, Gemini, etc.) and specify the model it is running. You can ask the tool directly with a question like, “What model are you based on?”.
- Prompt the AI to classify the three soils from Question 1. Some AI tools may allow you to upload the grain size distribution figure directly. Copy and paste the full conversation with the AI into your notebook or report, including your prompts and the AI’s responses.
- Reflect on the AI’s response. Specifically, compare its classifications to the ones you obtained manually.
- If the AI’s classification is incorrect, ask follow-up questions to clarify any misunderstandings. Consider pointing out any details the AI might have missed. If the AI provided correct results, challenge or question its response and ask it to assess its own confidence in the classification. Reflect on the AI’s updated response.

- Emphasize reflection, fact-checking AI responses, and evaluating their accuracy
- Each assignment integrates AI in a different role: topic exploration, tutoring support, and prompt experimentation

Feedback from the Pilot Implementation in CE 175

- How helpful was the programming assignment in improving your understanding of soil classification concepts?



• Student Feedback:

“It really helped me understand further how exactly soil classification worked. I felt the assignment was perfectly in the middle between easy and hard, it definitely made you think a little bit but nothing too crazy.”

Questions, Feedback, and Collaboration

- If you are interested in **reviewing draft assignments or pilot testing them**, please scan the QR code and provide your email address. Thank you!



Early Career Workshop Report

2025 USUCGER Early Career Workshop for Geotechnical Faculty

Susan Burns, Sheng Dai, David Frost, Carlos
Santamarina



Third Early Career Workshop Agenda

Wednesday October 15, 2025

Time	Agenda Topic	Location
4:00 – 5:30 pm	Arrival & hotel check-in	
5:30 – 7:30 pm	Welcome reception and icebreaker	Tech Square Tavern, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
	Dinner on your own, midtown Atlanta	

Thursday October 16, 2025

Time	Agenda Topic	Speaker	Location
8:00 – 9:00 am	Continental breakfast provided		Conference Dining Room, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
9:00 – 9:30 am	Welcome and Workshop overview Outline objectives, agenda, expected outcomes	Susan Burns, Jack Montgomery, and Giovanna Biscontin (tentative)	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
9:30 – 9:50 am	Advancing your academic career in a changing environment	Tim Lieuwen, Executive Vice President for Research, Georgia Tech	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
9:50 – 10:00 am	Break		
10:00 – 11:15 am	Research Strategies • Developing a research vision • High impact / low-cost research	Carlos Santamarina	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
11:15 am – 12:15 pm	Teaching Excellence Panel Teaching in the Age of AI Lesley Baradel , GT Biological Sciences Nimisha Roy , GT College of Computing Vincent Spezio , GT Center Teaching & Learning	Susan Burns, moderator	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
12:15 pm – 1:15 pm	Lunch		Conference Dining Room, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
1:15 – 2:30 pm	Practical Skills for Academics	Sheng Dai	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
2:30 – 3:00 pm	Break		
3:00 – 4:15 pm	Research Funding Panel Khalid Alahibi , University of Tennessee, Knoxville Jason DeJong , University California, Davis Scott Brandenburg , University of California, Los Angeles Joe Wartman , University of Washington	Jorge Macedo, moderator	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center

4:15 – 5:15 pm	Career Evolution For Academics and Their Students Carlos Santamarina Georgia Tech Rudy Bonaparte Geosyntec	Susan Burns, moderator	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
5:15 – 6:00 pm	Break		
6:00 pm	Workshop dinner		Conference Dining Room, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center

Friday October 17, 2025

Time	Agenda Topic	Speaker	Location
8:00 – 9:00 am	Continental breakfast provided		Conference Dining Room, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
9:00 – 10:30 am	Collaboration with Industry • Geosynthetics Institute • DFI • Entrepreneurship	David Frost Morgan NeSmith	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
10:30 – 11:30 am	CV "speed dating" with senior faculty reviewing	Sheng Dai	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center
11:30 – 12:00 pm	Workshop close/depart for airport	Susan Burns, Sheng Dai, David Frost, Carlos Santamarina	Conference Room 2, Georgia Tech Hotel and Conference Center

Workshop was funded by the National Science Foundation,
the USUCGER, the Deep Foundations Institute, and the
Georgia Institute of Technology



Third United States Universities Council on Geotechnical Education and Research Early Career



- 44 assistant professors from 42 universities
- Workshop sessions focused on:
 - Advancing an academic career in a changing environment
 - Research strategies: Developing vision and a high-impact research program



Third United States Universities Council on Geotechnical Education and Research Early Career Workshop

- Teaching in the age of AI
 - Lesley Baradel, GT Biological Sciences
 - Nimisha Roy, GT College of Computing
 - Vincent Spezzo, GT Center Teaching and Learning
- Federally funded research opportunities
 - Working with national labs, Khalid Alshibli, Univ of Tennessee, Knoxville
 - NHERI Network/Univ California Davis Centrifuge, Jason DeJong, UC, Davis
 - DesignSafe, Scott J. Brandenburg, University of California, Los Angeles
 - NHERI RAPID facility, Joseph Wartman, University of Washington



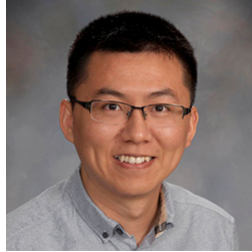
Workshop Sessions

- Entrepreneurship and Collaboration with Industry
 - David Frost
- Industry/academic collaboration
 - Morgan NeSmith, Berkel/DFI
- Career evolution for academics & their students who pursue careers in consulting
 - Carlos Santamarina / Rudy Bonaparte, Geosyntec
- Practical Skills for Academics
 - Sheng Dai
- CV “speed dating,” with GT senior faculty providing consultation and review on junior faculty CVs
- GT EVPR, Tim Lieuwen gave welcome session



USUCGER Awards

USUCGER Early Career Educator



*Cheng Zhu, Associate Professor
Rowan University*

USUCGER Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion



*Adda Athanasopoulos-Zekkos, Associate Professor
University of California, Berkeley*

USUCGER Student Travel Grants

Spring 2026

- Pingki Datta, PhD Student, Oregon State University, 2026 GeoCongress
- Alex Lefever, Senior Undergraduate Student, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology, 2026 GeoCongress

Fall 2025

- Sajan KC, PhD Candidate, University of Southern California, 2025 GeoExtreme

Summer 2025

- Avishek Ghosh, PhD Candidate, South Dakota State University, 2025 International Conference of Bio-mediated and Bio-inspired Geotechnics

USUCGER Future Objectives

Increase funds to support USUCGER initiatives:

- Currently, all funds come from member dues.
- Potential immediate strategy: Extend access to job postings on USUCGER site to industry and agencies for a fee (University postings remain free and separate)
 - Exclusive focus on geotech positions (MS, PhD only or also BS?)
 - No significant upgrade to website (only postings, no resume databases)
 - Fees to be used in support of other initiatives (e.g. student travel grants, special projects)
 - Fee TBD. For reference:
 - “basic” ASCE - between \$655 (30 days) and \$875 (90 days)
 - AGU – between \$655 for 30 days and \$1260 for 90 days
 - AEG – between \$150 (30 days) to \$400 (90 days)
- Suggestions, comments?

Increase funds to support USUCGER initiatives:

- Longer-term strategy: Raise USUCGER member dues
 - Currently \$25 per person per year (since 2004)
 - Structure and cycle likely to stay the same, only amount changes
 - Any changes will need to be approved by a membership vote
- Suggestions, comments?

What could we do with additional funds:

- Keep doing the things we have been doing, but reflect changes in cost:
 - Student travel grants that can better cover cost of attendance.
 - Special projects reflect costs of hiring a student
 - Higher workshop costs
- Website development
 - More capable website
 - Services to serve members

Promote more continuous engagement of USUCGER community:

- Currently, interaction between member is limited to annual meeting & happy hour at Geo-congress
- Possible strategies:
 - Additional semi-annual membership “virtual” meeting (late fall)
 - Short presentations from USUCGER award winners, recipients of special project grants and of travel fellowships
 - Update from board and input from membership
 - Regular (~every 3 months) virtual conversations around topics of broad interest to the community in form of presentations and/or panels.
 - Suggested first topic: implementing AI in geotechnical engineering education
- Interest, comments?

Updates from Other Organizations

Open Discussion and Questions